CHAPTER 2

Fundamentals of customer care

Unit A · Learning outcome LO1 · Model: the Kano Model

Not every feature of a service matters in the same way. Some are expected, some win customers, and a few surprise them. A manager must know which is which before spending money.

By the end of this chapter you can:

- sort the features of a service into basics, performance features and delighters
- map a customer journey and find its moments of truth
- decide where to invest first, and justify the choice

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Basic need	Something customers expect; they are angry when it is missing
Performance feature	The better it is, the happier the customer
Delighter	A pleasant surprise the customer did not expect
Moment of truth	A contact that shapes how the customer judges the whole business
Customer journey	Every step a customer takes, from first interest to after-sales
Journey map	A picture of the journey that shows what the customer does and feels at each step
Pain point	A step where the customer feels frustrated
Expectation	What the customer believes will happen

Core idea: expectations decide satisfaction

Customers judge service against what they expect. If you meet the expectation, they are calm. If you fall below it, they are unhappy, even if the service is "good". If you go above it, they remember you.

Expectations grow over time. Free Wi-Fi in a café was once a surprise. Today customers expect it, and they complain when it is missing. A delighter slowly becomes a basic.

The Level 5 model: the Kano Model

Professor Noriaki Kano and his colleagues (1984) sorted what customers want into three groups:

Group	If it is missing	If it is present	Example: a phone shop such as the store
Basic	Customers are angry	Customers say nothing; they expect it	The phone works; the price is correct
Performance	Customers are less happy	The better it is, the happier they are	Short waiting time; clear advice
Delighter	Nobody notices	Customers are surprised and pleased	Staff move your photos and contacts to the new phone for free

The lesson: **a delighter cannot save a missing basic.** A free gift means nothing if the phone does not work.

Use it in three steps

1. List the features of the service.
2. Sort each into basic, performance or delighter.
3. Protect the basics first, then compete on performance, then add one delighter.

SENTENCE FRAME

___ is a basic need, because customers are angry when it is missing.

Deeper theory

How customers form expectations

Customers do not arrive with empty minds. Their expectations come from several sources (Zeithaml, Berry and Parasuraman, 1993):

Source	Example
Past experience	"Last time my food came in 20 minutes."
Word of mouth	"My friend said the staff are very kind."
Online reviews and social media	"It has 4.8 stars on Google."
The company's own promises	"Delivery in 30 minutes or less."
Personal needs	A customer in a hurry expects speed.
Price	Customers expect more from a luxury hotel than a budget hotel.

Researchers also describe a **zone of tolerance**. Customers have a **desired** level of service (what they hope for) and an **adequate** level (the minimum they accept). Between the two is the zone of tolerance. If service falls below the adequate level, customers are unhappy. If it rises above the desired level, they are delighted.

Manager's lesson: be careful with promises. If your advert promises "30 minutes", you raise the adequate level. Promise what you can always deliver, then try to do a little better.

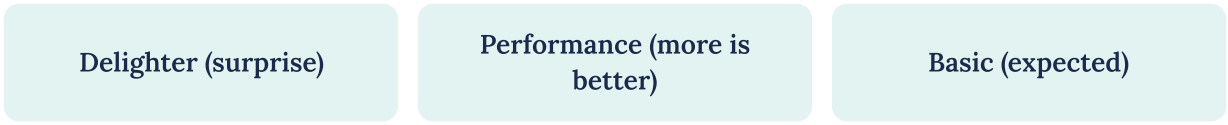
The Kano Model in more detail

Kano and colleagues (1984) also described two more groups of features, beyond basic, performance and delighters:

- **Indifferent features:** customers do not care if they are there or not. Example: the colour of the paper bag.
- **Reverse features:** some customers dislike them. Example: loud music in a café can please young customers but annoy others.

Kano also showed that features **move over time**. Today's delighter becomes tomorrow's performance feature, and later a basic. Mobile apps, free Wi-Fi and online tracking all followed this path.

Figure 2.1 How features move in the Kano Model over time



How companies use Kano in practice. They ask customers two questions about each feature: "How would you feel if this feature **was there**?" and "How would you feel if it **was not there**?" The pattern of answers shows which group the feature belongs to.

Moments of truth: first, second and zero

- The **first moment of truth** is when the customer meets the product or service, for example in the shop (term popularised by Procter & Gamble).
- The **second moment of truth** is when they use it at home.
- Google later added the **zero moment of truth (ZMOT)**: when customers research online **before** they buy (Lecinski, 2011). Today, many customers decide before they speak to anyone.

Customer journey mapping

A **customer journey map** shows the steps a customer takes, from first need to after-sales. A good map has five rows:

Row	Question
Stage	What step is the customer in? (Search, buy, use, get help)
Actions	What does the customer do?
Touchpoints	Where do they meet the business? (App, store, phone)
Feelings	How do they feel? (Happy, OK, unhappy)
Opportunities	How could we improve this step?

Journey maps work best when they are based on **real research**, such as interviews, observation and data, not only on managers' opinions.

Service blueprinting

A **service blueprint** goes deeper than a journey map. It shows what the customer sees and what happens **behind the scenes** (Shostack, 1984). It has layers:

1. **Customer actions:** what the customer does.
2. **Frontstage:** what staff do in front of the customer.
3. **Backstage:** what staff do that the customer cannot see.
4. **Support processes:** systems and other teams that make it possible.

A blueprint shows where things can go wrong, called **fail points**. For example, if the kitchen system does not send online orders to the screen, the customer only sees the result: a late meal.

Personas

A **persona** is a short description of a typical customer, based on research. For example:

> *"Mariam, 34, works full-time and has two children. She orders groceries by app on Thursday evenings. She values speed and correct orders more than price."*

Personas help staff and designers imagine real people when they design service. Use three to five personas, not one "average" customer.

Further reading

- Kano, N. et al. (1984). "Attractive Quality and Must-Be Quality". *Journal of the Japanese Society for Quality Control*, 14(2).
- Lecinski, J. (2011). *Winning the Zero Moment of Truth*. Google.
- Shostack, G. L. (1984). "Designing Services That Deliver". *Harvard Business Review*, January.

Tech layer: digital moments of truth and journey mapping

A **moment of truth** is any contact that makes the customer decide what they think of you. Many now happen on a screen before the customer meets a person:

- the first search result and its star rating
- the website on a phone: does it load fast and is it clear?
- the WhatsApp reply: minutes or days?
- the delivery tracking message
- the follow-up survey or review request

A **journey map** draws these steps in order. For each step, note what the customer does, what they feel, and the pain points. Then rank the weakest moments of truth: where is the gap between what customers expect and what they get the biggest?

Case study: pharmacy delivery on Talabat

Imagined scenario: the situation and numbers are invented for practice. They do not describe the real company.

Imagine a pharmacy in Doha starts home delivery through the **Talabat** app. It also launches its own loyalty app with games and points. Customer ratings stay low. Reviews say medicines arrive late and sometimes the wrong strength is delivered.

Analyse it with Kano. The correct medicine on time is a **basic** need. The games in the app are a **delighter**. The pharmacy invested in a delighter while a basic was failing. It should fix accuracy and delivery times first, then improve performance (for example, a 2-hour delivery window), and only then add delighters.

BRAND SPOTLIGHT

SAS Airlines: 50 million moments of truth

What happened. In the early 1980s, Jan Carlzon became the boss of SAS, the Scandinavian airline. The airline was losing money. Carlzon did a simple calculation. Each year about 10 million customers flew with SAS. Each customer met about five staff members, for about 15 seconds each time.

10 million × 5 = **50 million moments of truth** every year.

Why it matters. Carlzon said that in each of those short moments, the customer decides what they think of the whole airline. So he gave frontline staff more power to solve problems on the spot. He later wrote a famous book called *Moments of Truth* (1987).

The lesson for managers. Service is not one big event. It is thousands of small moments. Train and trust the people who are in those moments.

Word help: *frontline staff* = staff who meet customers face to face or on the phone.

BRAND SPOTLIGHT

Amazon Prime: when a delighter becomes a basic

What happened. In February 2005, Amazon started **Prime** in the United States. For US$79 a year, members got free two-day delivery on more than a million items. At that time, this was a big surprise for online shoppers. It was a **delighter**.

Why it matters. Other shops copied the idea. Soon, many customers began to **expect** fast, free delivery from every online shop. Today, slow or expensive delivery makes many online customers angry.

The lesson for managers. Delighters do not stay delighters. Over time they become **basic needs**. Check your Kano list every year. Yesterday's "wow" may be today's "of course".

BRAND SPOTLIGHT

Apple: delight in the small details

What happened. Apple designs the moment a customer opens the box of a new phone. The box opens slowly and neatly. The phone is the first thing you see. In Apple stores, staff at the Genius Bar help customers set up and repair their devices.

Why it matters. Customers expect a phone to work. That is a **basic**. But a beautiful unboxing and friendly expert help are **delighters**. People share photos and videos of opening their new phone.

The lesson for managers. Delighters can be small and cheap. Think about the moments your customers will remember and tell their friends about.

BRAND SPOTLIGHT

Nike By You: design your own shoes

What happened. In 1999 Nike launched **NIKEiD**, now called **Nike By You**. Customers can choose the colours and materials of their shoes online and add their own name or number. The first shoe customers could design was the Air Force 1.

Why it matters. In 1999, designing your own shoes was a big surprise: a **delighter**. Today many sportswear and fashion brands offer personalisation, and some customers now expect it.

The lesson for managers. Personalisation can delight customers, but delighters slowly become **performance features** or even **basics**. Keep watching what your customers expect next.

QATAR SPOTLIGHT

Hamad International Airport: the world's best airport

What happened. Hamad International Airport in Doha was named the **World's Best Airport** at the Skytrax World Airport Awards in **2021, 2022 and 2024**. In 2024 it also won the award for the World's Best Airport Shopping.

Why it matters. An airport journey has many moments of truth: check-in, security, finding the gate, shops and restaurants, transfers, baggage and finally leaving the airport. Each one can make a passenger happy or angry.

The lesson for managers. To be the best, every moment of truth must work. Basics come first: a clean, safe airport and fast security. Delighters, such as art, shopping and quiet areas, help passengers remember the airport.

Is this model perfect?

Strengths of the Kano Model	Limits of the Kano Model
Simple: only three groups	Customers do not always agree; one person's delighter is another person's basic
Helps managers decide where to spend money first	Groups change over time, so the list must be checked often
Reminds us that basics must never fail	Needs research to sort features correctly; guessing is risky
Works for products and services	Does not tell you how much to spend on each feature

How to use this in an answer: "Using Kano, ___ is a basic. However, different customer groups may see it differently, so I would survey ___."

Useful language

Checking expectations

- "What is most important to you today: speed, price or something else?"
- "Before we start, can I explain what will happen next?"

Managing expectations honestly

- "Your order will be ready by 4 pm. I'll message you if anything changes."
- "I can't do ___, but I can do ___. Would that help?"

Creating a small delighter

- "I noticed it's your birthday. Happy birthday from all of us!"
- "While you wait, can I offer you some water?"

Practice case: a busy Starbucks

Imagined scenario: the situation and numbers are invented for practice. They do not describe the real company.

Imagine you manage a busy **Starbucks** branch in a Doha mall. You have a budget of $40,000 and three ideas:

1. A new seating area with sofas and phone chargers ($35,000).
2. More mobile order-ahead pick-up shelves and a second barista at peak times ($30,000 per year).
3. Staff write a friendly message on the cup of regular customers (almost free).

Your customer survey says:

- 41% of customers say they wait more than 10 minutes for a drink at lunchtime.
- 12% say there are not enough seats.
- 9 customers wrote, "The barista remembered my name and my drink. I was so happy!" This happens by chance, not as a policy.

Guided questions

1. **Analyse:** Write the customer journey from "I want a coffee" to "I leave the café". Mark three moments of truth.
2. **Analyse:** Sort the three ideas into basic, performance or delighter. Explain each choice.
3. **Evaluate:** Which pain point is most serious? Use the survey numbers.

4. **Recommend:** Your budget is $40,000. Which ideas would you choose? Justify your choice with Kano.
5. **Evaluate:** Name one risk of your choice and how to reduce it.

Hint: a basic that is failing comes before any delighter.

Think local

Think about ordering food with **Talabat** or **Snoonu**, or booking a ride with **Careem** or **Uber**.

1. List the steps of the journey, from opening the app to finishing your meal or ride.
2. Which features are **basics**, **performance** features and **delighters**?
3. What was a delighter a few years ago that you now **expect**?

Teachers: replace these brands with any brands your students know well.

Common mistakes managers make

- **Spending on delighters while a basic is broken.** A free gift cannot fix a wrong order.
- **Thinking a delighter lasts forever.** Customers get used to it. It becomes a basic.
- **Mapping the journey from the company's view.** Walk the journey as the customer: start from their first search, not from your sales counter.
- **Forgetting digital moments of truth.** Many customers judge you on your website or WhatsApp reply before they meet a person.

Apply it: a simple journey map

Choose one service, for example booking a doctor's appointment.

1. Write the steps in order, from "I need a doctor" to "I am home after the visit".
2. Under each step, write what the customer **does** and how they **feel**: happy, OK or unhappy.
3. Mark the steps where the customer feels unhappy. These are the pain points.
4. For each step, write B (basic), P (performance) or D (delighter) for what the customer needs most.
5. Choose the weakest moment of truth. Write one way to fix it.

Chapter summary

- Customers judge service **against what they expect**.
- The **Kano Model** has three groups: **basics** (expected), **performance** (more is better) and **delighters** (nice surprises).
- **Fix basics first**, then improve performance, then add a delighter.
- Delighters become basics over time.
- A **moment of truth** is any contact that shapes the customer's opinion. Many are now digital.
- A **journey map** shows each step, what the customer does and feels, and the pain points.

Review quiz

1. Customers are angry when this is missing, but say nothing when it is there. It is a...
   a. delighter
   b. performance feature
   c. basic need
   d. moment of truth
2. Jan Carlzon counted 50 million moments of truth because...
   a. SAS had 50 million staff
   b. 10 million customers each met about 5 staff members
   c. each flight had 50 seats
   d. customers flew 50 times a year
3. Free two-day delivery was a delighter in 2005. Today many customers see it as...
   a. a delighter
   b. a basic need
   c. a pain point
   d. not important
4. What should a manager fix first?
   a. a missing basic
   b. a new delighter
   c. the advertising
   d. the uniforms
5. A pain point on a journey map is...
   a. a step where the customer pays
   b. a step where the customer feels frustrated
   c. the first step of the journey
   d. a delighter

Check your understanding

1. Name one basic, one performance feature and one delighter at a hotel you know.
2. Give an example of a delighter that has become a basic.
3. Describe three digital moments of truth for an online shop.
4. What three things does a journey map show at each step?
5. *Level 5 question:* A manager has budget for one project: a new waiting area with free coffee, or a system that cuts waiting time by half. Use Kano to recommend one.

Capstone step 2

Map the customer journey of your chosen organisation, from first contact to after-sales. Mark the moments of truth and **rank the three weakest**, with a reason for each.